



Integrating GEDSI: Insights from the National Level Panel Discussion at the Nepal Shelter Forum. Photo: Nepal Shelter Forum, 2024

Nepal: Journey of Partnership and Capacity Strengthening

LESSONS ON THE DEVELOPMENT OF A NATIONAL GENDER EQUALITY,
DISABILITY & SOCIAL INCLUSION (GEDSI) IN DRRM STRATEGIC ACTION PLAN



Background: CRS and Localization

Catholic Relief Services' commitment to partnership and capacity strengthening places people, communities, and partners at the forefront of its work. This experience with partners, as well as CRS' own mission and values, requires that CRS supports the emergence of local leadership and the growth of locally led humanitarian and development efforts. Our experience has taught us that CRS partners embrace opportunities for leadership and influencing local institutions and CRS is committed to supporting their growth as new opportunities emerge.



Disasters and Social Inclusion in Nepal

- Each year Nepal experiences multiple natural disasters such as monsoon floods, landslides, fires and drought.
- Most parts of the country are also seismically active. In April and May 2015 two massive earthquakes struck Nepal with over eight million people affected.
- Disasters do not affect everyone in the same way.
- Unequal power dynamics and social exclusion impact the way people are affected by disasters and their capacity to withstand and recover from them.
- 15.1 per cent or 4.53 M out of the 30 M population live below the poverty line, majority of them living in rural areas of the country.
- In Nepal, exclusion is linked to caste, ethnicity, religion, language and gender. There have also been historically excluded groups in terms of access, social capital and governance.
- There is very low participation of women and excluded groups in the federal, provincial, and local DRRM structures.



CRS in Nepal

Drawing on its experience responding to the 2015 earthquakes in Nepal, CRS Nepal is supporting national and local government and partner organizations to strengthen their capacity on multi hazard response and recovery. CRS has also been implementing projects focused on building safer communities through its Home & Communities program, as well as on agriculture and livelihoods.

Since 2017, CRS has been the lead agency of the National Housing, Settlement Resilience Platform (NHSRP), which provides which provides coordination, information management services and technical advice to the National Disaster Risk Reduction Management Authority (NDRRMA), implementing partners and other stakeholders in the disaster recovery process. NDRRMA is the national government agency tasked with effectively carrying out and managing disaster management activities all over Nepal with support from its provincial, district and local units. Building on this long-standing partnership, CRS and NDRRMA realized that it could also work together to meet NDRRMA's long term institutional strengthening goals, given its mandate and institutional capacity strengthening needs as a newly-established government agency.



Ms. Manju Kumari Pokhrel, the DRRM and GEDSI focal person from the Provincial Ministry of Internal Affairs and Law (MolAL), shared her experiences and the current status of the provincial government in achieving gender equality, promoting gender justice, and fostering an inclusive society dedicated to child rights and equality for girls during a three-day training program. Photo: NHSRP



Our main area of focus through EMPOWER Asia would be on 1) Strengthening Disaster Risk Governance at Federal, Provincial and Local Levels 2) Enhanced Disaster preparedness for effective response of National, provincial, and local levels through regional and international collaborating and partnership within government and development partners which provide support to exchange standards, protocols and systems on disaster preparedness and response."

– NDRRMA staff, Expression of Interest

In October 2021, the CRS Asia Region launched EMPOWER Asia, Empowering Partners Working on Emergency Responses in Asia, as the region's primary mechanism for investing in strengthening the capacity of strategic partners to play leading roles in humanitarian response. In March 2022, CRS Nepal was selected as the first CRS country program to participate in EMPOWER Asia with a government partner, NDRRMA.

One year after the start of the project, CRS and NDRRMA managed to successfully develop the strategic action plan(SAP) on the integration of Gender Equality, Disability and Social Inclusion (GEDSI) in disaster risk reduction and management in Nepal. It was a lengthy process that involved a series of workshops, multi-stakeholder consultations and review processes. The following are the lessons learned so far:



Focusing on high level shared priorities on GEDSI integration in humanitarian response



Engagement of government leadership at all stages of GEDSI action plan development process.



Dedicated staffing from government and CRS steered the the policy development process.



Leveraging relationships and technical staff capacities: long-term partnership CRS/NHSRP & NDRRMA



Limit the number of planned activities: prioritize activities (what is realistic and feasible to implement)



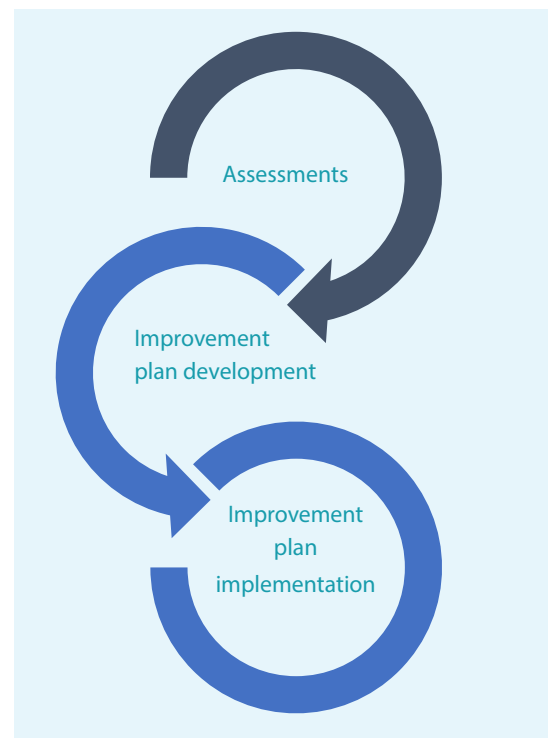
Working with the Government in Strategic Action Plan Development and Roll Out is a Multi-Year Process: GEDSI SAP (in gov approval process) CRS is planning activities within a three year timeframe to pilot.





EMPOWER Asia Institutional Strengthening Process in Nepal

- **Step 1:** By July 2021, NDRRMA, accompanied by CRS completed a capacity assessment using the EMPOWER Asia government partner institutional capacity assessment tool
- **Step 2:** NDRRMA developed an initial improvement plan focused on:
 - 1. Increased collaboration with housing and settlement actors at national and regional levels
 - 2. Policy development and capacity building on Gender Equality, Disability & Social Inclusion (GEDSI) integration in Disaster Risk Reduction
 - 3. Strengthening NDRRMA Monitoring and Evaluation system
 - 4. Development of an accessible and inclusive feedback and complaint mechanism for private housing reconstruction.
- **Step 3:** CRS and NDRRMA worked on the improvement plan implementation, grounded on CRS' Partner Capacity Strengthening Approach of Institutional Strengthening, Capacity Building and Accompaniment.



Focusing on GEDSI integration in DRRM

The lack of clarity on the concept of Gender Equality, Disability and Social Inclusion (GEDSI) in the broader dimension of Disaster Risk Reduction and Management led NDRRMA to look at how it can integrate GEDSI in its policies and programs.

The process started in September 2022 with an initial workshop with NDRRMA, donors and NGO representatives to have a common understanding of GEDSI concepts in DRR context and its integration in DRRM. An inter-ministry level GEDSI task force was established to lead the development of the GEDSI strategic action plan. This was followed by a series of national and local consultations, and review process towards the development of NDRRMA's GEDSI Strategic Action Plan. On May 03 2024, the GEDSI SAP was endorsed from the NDRRMA executive committee.



Timeline of the GEDSI Strategic Development Process





Results and Learnings

The GEDSI SAP is approved by NDRRMA executive committee and endorsed during Nepal shelter Forum (NSF) 2024, CRS and NDRRMA has already started the follow up activities to pilot the roll out of SAP at the provincial and municipal levels, to review and integrate the learnings before it is rolled out across the country. This will be a multi-year process that will involve capacity building and accompaniment activities (mentoring, coaching, etc.) as well as documentation of learning.



CRS' Capacity Strengthening Approach



Lessons Learned from the GEDSI SAP Development



Focusing on high level shared priorities: GEDSI integration in humanitarian response is a priority area for both agencies with senior leadership buy in and technical staff to provide support



Engagement of government leadership at all stages of the process: NDRRMA senior leadership was engaged in the GEDSI policy development process. It's important that CRS and partners communicate information, timelines, and decisions in a timely manner.



Dedicated staffing from government and CRS: Government strategic action plan(SAP) development is a lengthy process with several consultations at multiple levels and review steps involved. NDRRMA appointed joint secretary with dedicated staff who steered the SAP development process. Close accompaniment from CRS staff also enabled provision of timely support during the time taking implementation process.



Leveraging relationships and technical staff capacities: The long-term partnership between CRS/ NHSRP and NDRRMA has already established good working relationships which helped with the planning, implementation and follow up activities. CRS' role was to accompany NDRRMA in the process through a supportive advisory role, CRS also managed to tap in country and regional staff technical support on GEDSI in a timely manner.



Limit the number of planned activities: Out of four priority areas in the improvement plan only one was successfully completed after one and half year. While institutional strengthening takes time, it is important that both partners agree to prioritize a limited number of activities based on what is realistic and feasible to implement within the funding period as well as ensure alignment of the implementation schedule with government priorities. Competing priorities, high staff turnover, different scope for planning.



Working with the Government in SAP Development and Roll Out is a Multi-Year Process: The GEDSI SAP is approved by NDRRMA executive committee and endorsed during Nepal shelter Forum (NSF) 2024, CRS is planning follow up activities within a three year timeframe. This includes pilot the roll out the new policy, including related staff capacity building activities as well as documentation of learnings before roll out across the country. Additional accompaniment from CRS through consistent follow up activities towards the application and formalization of the GEDSI SAP.